7 From executable specifications to rock-solid automated acceptance tests

This chapter covers

- The importance of writing high-quality automated tests
- Preparing test data for the tests
- Implementing reliable and sustainable tests

In the next few chapters, we'll look at turning the automated scenarios we discussed in chapter 6 into fully automated acceptance tests for different types of applications and technologies.

When automated acceptance tests are poorly designed, they can add to the maintenance overhead, costing more to update and fix when new features are added than they contribute in value to the project. For this reason, it's important to design your acceptance tests well. In this chapter, we'll look at a number of techniques and patterns that can help you write automated acceptance tests that are meaningful, reliable, and maintainable (see figure 7.1).

Over the previous few chapters, you've seen how the BDD lifecycle takes acceptance criteria and turns them into executable specifications (see figure 7.2). Acceptance criteria are those brief notes you write on the back of your story cards that help define when a story or feature is complete. As you've seen, you can write more complete versions of these acceptance criteria in the form of scenarios, which